independence for Venezuela in a bloody war with the Spaniards. Cuba, though, remained loyal to Madrid throughout the first half of the nineteenth century. The Cubans first rebelled against their Spanish rulers in 1868, but the revolt was crushed after a ten-year struggle. They rebelled again in 1879, and yet again in 1895. This time they had a powerful ally, the United States of America.[6]

American troops landed on the beaches of Cuba in June 1898. The US government entered the conflict partly in response to public demand to stop Spanish atrocities against the Cubans, widely covered and often exaggerated in the American media. But behind the move was also the implementation of the decades-old Monroe Doctrine. Back in 1823, in the midst of Latin American revolutions, President James Monroe had declared that his country would treat any European interference in the region intended to establish control over newly independent states as a "manifestation of an unfriendly disposition toward the United States." The Monroe Doctrine was born. In 1898 it acquired a new meaning: the Americans were ready not only to protect the independence of Latin American countries but also to bring it about. The Spaniards found themselves obliged to withdraw and renounce their claims to Cuba. Cuban independence—received, unlike most sovereignties in the region, from American hands—was proclaimed in 1902.

In 1820 Thomas Jefferson had regarded Cuba as a potential new US state. In 1902, there was no appetite in Washington to extend American borders to include Cuba, but neither was there much desire to make it fully independent. The Platt Amendment to the US Army Appropriations Act of 1901, named after its principal author, Senator Orville H. Platt, limited Cuban sovereignty by giving the US government the right to have military bases on the island and intervene in Cuba's internal affairs for the sake of "good governance." The amendment established Cuba as a de facto American protectorate and served as a rallying point for Cuban rebels and revolutionaries, of whom there would be no shortage in the decades to come. The new masters against whom the Cubans rebelled were American, not Spanish.[7]

In all but name Cuba became a colony of the United States in the Caribbean. Most of the assets in the agricultural sector, mining, utilities,